



POWER STRUGGLES

Is oil really the villain? Oil has single-handedly revolutionized our lives. When did it suddenly become the villain? Who (or what) is really to blame?

By *Anirudh Regidi*
anirudh.regidi@thinkdigit.com

The birth of the universe was a truly cataclysmic event on a scale that is simply unimaginable to the mere human. The single most important consequence of the “big bang” was the birth of energy in the void. This energy is the one resource that we will ultimately run out of. One hundred billion years from now, the universe will be dead, it will simply have run out of energy and all forms of matter will just dissipate into nothingness, like the dying embers of a flame. This is inevitable and there is absolutely nothing that can be done about it. Energy is quite simply, the single most precious resource we have. We are all familiar with the law

of conservation of energy, but what we miss out is that the energy is lost forever. It’s transformed, but also lost. Life on this planet is driven by a quest for energy; energy to live, to survive, to thrive as a species. Without enough energy, any living being will just die. We humans are at the top of the food chain, not because we eat the most food, but because we consume the most energy. We have a penchant for ruining our surroundings in the quest for greater power, killing off all that is beautiful in favor of all that is functional. We would rather have a road than a river, a mall over a playground. Oil (and pollution) is just a consequence of that quest. We are, quite simply, the greediest species on the planet, a species for which no amount of power is enough. There are always those who are different, but there are simply not enough of them.

Living it up

While most animals just live to survive, as humans, we want much more from life than just survival. Animals also want more than just survival; they want a comfortable life, a food source that is rich, an absence of predators or competition, the freedom to reproduce and so on. Humans want the same things, but this is also where we differentiate ourselves from those animals. We can quantify our needs and do something about them on a much grander scale, think ahead and not rely solely on instinct. We actively strive to “improve” our surroundings to better suit

our need to survive. Unfortunately, we’re also horrendously irresponsible, lazy and cannot, or will not, define a limit to the degree of survival that is acceptable. There is always someone that wants that little bit more, who will push that little bit harder and use up that little bit more for that fractional improvement in comfort. It’s not that other animals are more responsible or clean. It’s just that they do less harm and don’t know enough to be truly greedy.

Jevons Paradox

This paradox is the proposition that “technological progress that increases the efficiency with which a resource is used tends to increase the consumption of that resource.” Does it seem illogical? Think about the industrial revolution. Coal had been in use since long before the industrial revolution ever came about; it’s just that we never saw any greater use for it other than as a fuel in a hearth to keep ourselves warm. Better methods of harnessing that power were being worked on, but it wasn’t till the invention of the steam engine that we saw the true potential of coal. Suddenly, here was this super-abundant resource that could be used to power just about everything. Who needed windmills or water wheels anymore? One steam engine could replace fifty horses. You suddenly had trains, factories, power stations, massive machines, faster ships and transport. Equally as sudden was the realization that we just didn’t have enough of it. It doesn’t even have to be



You would never find a monkey doing this